

D120

Special Populations Primary Care for the Advanced Practice Nurse

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A 78-year-old retired carpenter who still gardens daily reports trouble sleeping. He has taken an over-the-counter nighttime pain reliever containing diphenhydramine for three weeks, and his daughter says he seems foggy in the mornings and has had trouble starting his urine stream. His blood pressure is well controlled. What is the best recommendation?

- A. Stop the diphenhydramine product and start sleep hygiene and other non-drug measures.
- B. Continue it, since over-the-counter products are safe at labeled doses.
- C. Keep the sleep aid and start a medication for urinary hesitancy.
- D. Switch to a second over-the-counter sleep aid with doxylamine.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An older adult has new confusion, constipation, dry mouth, and urinary retention. Which medication on her list is the most likely cause?

- A. Lisinopril for blood pressure.
- B. Vitamin D supplement.
- C. Oxybutynin for overactive bladder.
- D. Acetaminophen for knee pain.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

An 84-year-old woman in assisted living, who is a former librarian and plays bridge weekly, has become confused and fallen twice in two days. Her temperature is 37.1 °C and she denies pain. Her son says she recently changed hair salons. What is the most appropriate next step?

- A. Evaluate for an acute cause, including infection, with exam, urinalysis, and basic labs.
- B. Advise physical therapy for the falls only.
- C. Diagnose progression of dementia and adjust her care plan.
- D. Rule out infection because she has no fever.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A 79-year-old man who was a high school principal was admitted for hip surgery. Two days after the operation his wife says he is alert and chatting one hour and drowsy and unable to follow a conversation the next. He had no memory problems before surgery. His daughter is flying in from overseas. Which condition is most likely?

- A. Normal aging.
- B. Alzheimer disease.
- C. Delirium.
- D. Major depressive disorder.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which history best supports dementia rather than delirium?

- A. Confusion that began yesterday and comes and goes.
- B. Slowly worsening memory over two years, with normal alertness and attention.
- C. Any memory complaint in a person over 80.
- D. Sudden inattention after starting a new sleep medicine.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A 31-year-old software engineer with chronic hypertension controlled on lisinopril says she and her partner plan to start trying for a baby in the next few months. She runs 5K races and her last Pap test was normal. What is the most important medication change to recommend now?

- A. Stop all blood pressure medication because she is fit.
- B. Keep lisinopril until she has a positive pregnancy test, then stop it.
- C. Switch lisinopril to a pregnancy-compatible antihypertensive such as labetalol or nifedipine, and start folic acid.
- D. Switch lisinopril to losartan.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

An 80-year-old woman weighs 60 kg today; she weighed 66 kg a year ago. Her serum creatinine is 1.0 mg/dL, which the lab flags as normal. She volunteers at a food bank twice a week. Using Cockcroft-Gault, what is her estimated creatinine clearance?

- A. About 50 mL/min
- B. About 42.5 mL/min
- C. About 47 mL/min
- D. Normal, because the creatinine is flagged normal.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	____	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Four patients each have a serum creatinine of 1.0 mg/dL. Using Cockcroft-Gault, which one has the lowest creatinine clearance?

- A. An 85-year-old woman weighing 50 kg.
- B. An 85-year-old man weighing 50 kg.
- C. A 45-year-old man weighing 90 kg.
- D. A 45-year-old woman weighing 90 kg.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	____	

9.

A 58-year-old man with a master's degree, newly diagnosed with type 2 diabetes, is starting metformin and home glucose checks. He is a regional sales manager and travels most weeks. After the explanation he nods and says he understands. What is the best way to confirm understanding?

- A. Skip teach-back because his education level shows high health literacy.
- B. Give him a detailed printed handout instead of discussing it.
- C. Ask "Do you have any questions?" and end the visit if he says no.
- D. Ask him to explain in his own words how and when he will take the medicine and check his glucose.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	____	

10.

A 34-year-old transgender man who has taken testosterone for six years comes in for a routine visit. He works as a firefighter and his legal documents list his gender as male. He has not had gender-affirming genital surgery and his last cervical screening was seven years ago. Which screening is due?

- A. Prostate cancer screening instead.
- B. No cervical screening, because his legal gender is male.
- C. No cervical screening, because testosterone removes cervical cancer risk.
- D. Cervical cancer screening, following the same intervals as for any person with a cervix.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A 60-year-old transgender woman who has had vaginoplasty but kept her prostate asks which screening applies to her. Which organ-based screening decision is correct?

- A. Stop all cancer screening after surgery.
- B. Cervical cytology screening of the neovagina.
- C. No prostate discussion, because her gender identity is female.
- D. Discuss prostate cancer screening, since the prostate is still present.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

At an annual visit, a 76-year-old woman who lives with her two cats says she slipped and fell in her kitchen last month but was not hurt. She takes a daily multivitamin and enjoys book club. Which next step best matches current fall-prevention practice?

- A. No action needed, because she was not injured.
- B. Assess gait and balance (e.g., Timed Up and Go), review medications, and build a multifactorial prevention plan.
- C. Advise her to give away her cats.
- D. Start vitamin D solely to prevent falls in all older adults.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

A 78-year-old ~~retired carpenter who still gardens daily~~ reports trouble sleeping. He has taken an over-the-counter nighttime pain reliever containing diphenhydramine for three weeks, and his daughter says he seems foggy in the mornings and has had trouble starting his urine stream. ~~His blood pressure is well controlled.~~ What is the best recommendation?

Target word: medication management **Decides:** Diphenhydramine is strongly anticholinergic and on the Beers list.

A	Correct	Anticholinergic effects explain the fogginess and urinary hesitancy; deprescribing comes first.
B	Absolute language	OTC status does not make a drug safe for older adults.
C	Dropped element	Treats a side effect with another drug instead of removing the cause (a prescribing cascade).
D	Confusion set	Doxylamine is also a first-generation, anticholinergic antihistamine.

2. Answer C Concept 1 · transfer

An older adult has new confusion, constipation, dry mouth, and urinary retention. Which medication on her list is the most likely cause?

Target word: work backward from symptoms to the drug **Decides:** The pattern is anticholinergic.

A	Adjacent category	ACE inhibitors cause cough and high potassium, not an anticholinergic pattern.
B	Confusion set	Routine vitamin D does not produce this pattern.
C	Correct	Oxybutynin is a strongly anticholinergic Beers-list drug matching every symptom.
D	Inverted operation	Acetaminophen is a preferred, non-anticholinergic analgesic for older adults.

3. Answer A Concept 2

An 84-year-old woman in assisted living, ~~who is a former librarian and plays bridge weekly,~~ has become confused and fallen twice in two days. Her temperature is 37.1 °C and she denies pain. ~~Her son says she recently changed hair salons.~~ What is the most appropriate next step?

Target word: next step for acute change **Decides:** Acute confusion and falls may be the only sign of infection or other acute illness.

A	Correct	Older adults often present atypically; an acute change needs a search for the cause.
B	Dropped element	Treats the falls without addressing the new confusion and its cause.
C	Confusion set	Dementia changes gradually; two days of change is acute.
D	Absolute language	Older adults often have no fever with serious infection.

4. Answer C Concept 3

A 79-year-old man ~~who was a high school principal~~ was admitted for hip surgery. Two days after the operation his wife says he is alert and chatting one hour and drowsy and unable to follow a conversation the next. He had no memory problems before surgery. ~~His daughter is flying in from overseas.~~ Which condition is most likely?

Target word: classify the confusion **Decides:** Acute onset with fluctuating attention and alertness.

A	Inverted operation	Sudden fluctuating confusion is never normal aging.
B	Confusion set	Alzheimer disease develops gradually over months to years.
C	Correct	Acute, fluctuating attention and level of consciousness after surgery is classic delirium.
D	Adjacent category	Depression can mimic cognitive decline but does not cause hour-to-hour swings in alertness.

5. Answer B Concept 3 • transfer

Which history best supports dementia rather than delirium?

Target word: reverse: pick the dementia pattern **Decides:** Gradual onset over months with intact attention.

A	Inverted operation	Acute, fluctuating confusion is delirium.
B	Correct	Gradual course with preserved attention fits dementia.
C	Absolute language	Age alone does not establish dementia.
D	Adjacent category	Drug-induced sudden change is delirium.

6. Answer C Concept 4

A 31-year-old ~~software engineer~~ with chronic hypertension controlled on lisinopril says she and her partner plan to start trying for a baby in the next few months. ~~She runs 5K races and her last Pap test was normal.~~ What is the most important medication change to recommend now?

Target word: preconception medication change **Decides:** ACE inhibitors are fetotoxic.

A	Camouflage	Running does not remove the need to control chronic hypertension.
B	Dropped element	Planning ahead avoids exposure in the weeks before pregnancy is known.
C	Correct	ACE inhibitors should be replaced before conception; folic acid lowers neural tube defect risk.
D	Confusion set	ARBs carry the same fetal risks as ACE inhibitors.

7. Answer B Concept 5

An 80-year-old woman weighs 60 kg today; ~~she weighed 66 kg a year ago.~~ Her serum creatinine is 1.0 mg/dL, which the lab flags as normal. ~~She volunteers at a food bank twice a week.~~ Using Cockcroft-Gault, what is her estimated creatinine clearance?

Target word: estimated CrCl **Decides:** $(140 - 80) \times 60 / (72 \times 1.0) \times 0.85$.

A	Dropped element	Leaves out the 0.85 female factor.
B	Correct	$60 \times 60 = 3,600$; $3,600 / 72 = 50$; $50 \times 0.85 = 42.5$ mL/min.
C	Wrong stem number	Uses last year's 66 kg weight.
D	Absolute language	A normal-range creatinine can hide reduced clearance in a small older woman.

8. Answer A Concept 5 • transfer

Four patients each have a serum creatinine of 1.0 mg/dL. Using Cockcroft-Gault, which one has the lowest creatinine clearance?

Target word: solve for which patient **Decides:** Older age, lower weight, and female sex all lower CrCl.

A	Correct	$55 \times 50 / 72 \times 0.85 \approx 32$ mL/min, the lowest.
B	Dropped element	Same age and weight but no 0.85 factor: about 38 mL/min.
C	Inverted operation	Younger and heavier raises clearance: about 119 mL/min, the highest.
D	Adjacent category	Female sex alone does not outweigh her younger age and higher weight: about 101 mL/min.

9. Answer D Concept 6

A 58-year-old man ~~with a master's degree~~, newly diagnosed with type 2 diabetes, is starting metformin and home glucose checks. ~~He is a regional sales manager and travels most weeks.~~ After the explanation he nods and says he understands. What is the best way to confirm understanding?

Target word: confirming understanding **Decides:** Teach-back is used with every patient.

A	Camouflage	Formal education does not guarantee health literacy; teach-back is universal.
B	Dropped element	Written material supports but does not confirm understanding.
C	Adjacent category	A yes/no question does not show what he understood.
D	Correct	Teach-back confirms understanding and exposes gaps, regardless of education.

10. Answer D Concept 7

A 34-year-old transgender man who has taken testosterone for six years comes in for a routine visit. ~~He works as a firefighter and his legal documents list his gender as male.~~ He has not had gender-affirming genital surgery and his last cervical screening was seven years ago. Which screening is due?

Target word: screening decision **Decides:** He still has a cervix.

A	Confusion set	He has no prostate; screening follows organs present.
B	Camouflage	Legal documents do not change anatomy or cancer risk.
C	Absolute language	Testosterone does not eliminate cervical cancer risk.
D	Correct	Screening follows the organs present; his cervix is overdue.

11. Answer D Concept 7 • transfer

A 60-year-old transgender woman who has had vaginoplasty but kept her prostate asks which screening applies to her. Which organ-based screening decision is correct?

Target word: reverse direction: transgender woman **Decides:** The prostate remains after vaginoplasty.

A	Absolute language	Other age-based screenings still apply.
B	Confusion set	A neovagina has no cervix; cervical screening does not apply.
C	Inverted operation	Identity does not remove the organ.
D	Correct	Screening follows the organs present; the prostate is retained.

12. Answer B Concept 8

At an annual visit, a 76-year-old woman ~~who lives with her two cats~~ says she slipped and fell in her kitchen last month but was not hurt. ~~She takes a daily multivitamin and enjoys book club.~~ Which next step best matches current fall-prevention practice?

Target word: next step after a reported fall **Decides:** A reported fall triggers gait and balance assessment and a multifactorial plan.

A	Dropped element	Any fall raises future risk, injured or not.
B	Correct	A fall in the past year is a positive screen and calls for assessment and intervention.
C	Camouflage	Answers the pet detail; it is not the evidence-based first step.
D	Adjacent category	Vitamin D alone is not recommended to prevent falls in community-dwelling older adults without deficiency.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	7	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	5	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	4	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Potentially inappropriate medications in older adults	The Beers Criteria flag drugs to avoid in older adults, notably strongly anticholinergic agents such as first-generation antihistamines, because of confusion, falls, and urinary retention.	Assuming an over-the-counter drug is safe for an older adult because it is sold without a prescription.	An older adult taking a sleep aid, allergy pill, or muscle relaxant.
2	Atypical presentation in older adults	Infection and acute illness in older adults often show up as new confusion, falls, or functional decline, without fever or localized symptoms.	Ruling out infection because there is no fever.	A sudden change in behavior or function in an older adult.
3	Delirium vs. dementia	Delirium is acute in onset with fluctuating attention and level of consciousness and is usually reversible; dementia is gradual, with attention intact until late.	Labeling new confusion as worsening dementia.	Time course (hours to days vs. months to years) and attention.
4	Medication safety before and during pregnancy	Known teratogens such as ACE inhibitors, ARBs, warfarin, isotretinoin, and valproate should be switched or stopped before conception in someone planning pregnancy, and folic acid started.	Waiting for a positive pregnancy test to change a teratogenic drug.	A patient of reproductive age on a chronic medication who says she wants to conceive.
5	Renal dose adjustment (Cockcroft-Gault)	$CrCl = (140 - \text{age}) \times \text{weight in kg} / (72 \times \text{serum creatinine})$, $\times 0.85$ for females; older, smaller patients can have low clearance with a normal-looking creatinine.	Reading a normal serum creatinine as normal kidney function in an older adult.	Age, weight, sex, and serum creatinine given together.
6	Health literacy and teach-back	Use plain language and teach-back (the patient explains the plan in their own words) with every patient, not only those who seem to struggle.	Asking “Do you have any questions?” and taking silence as understanding.	A new or complex regimen with a patient who nods along.
7	Organ-based screening for transgender patients	Screen for the organs a patient currently has, regardless of gender identity (e.g., cervical screening for a transgender man with a cervix).	Screening by listed gender marker instead of anatomy.	A transgender patient due for cancer screening.
8	Fall risk screening in older adults	Ask all older adults yearly about falls; a fall, fear of falling, or unsteadiness leads to a gait/balance test (e.g., Timed Up and Go of 12 seconds or more = higher risk) and a multifactorial plan.	Only assessing fall risk after an injury.	An older adult who reports a fall or unsteadiness during a routine visit.

Course scope (public description): Special Populations Primary Care for the Advanced Practice Nurse prepares the graduate nursing student to perform the role of an advanced practice nurse with the essential competencies and skills necessary to provide primary healthcare to unique patient populations in the outpatient setting. This course will prepare the graduate nursing student to demonstrate competence in leading health promotion and disease prevention activities; in diagnosing, managing, and coordinating care for patients with specific disease processes; and in empowering patients and their families in pursuing positive health outcomes. This course will also prepare the graduate nursing student to collaborate with unique patient populations and their families in developing effective plans of care that build self-efficacy in the process of preventing and treating specific disease processes. There are no prerequisites for this course.